

2020 A-level Paper 2 : The Art and Science of Apologising

Suggested Answer Scheme (*Examiners' Comments in italics*)

1. In paragraph 1, the author presents herself as a person who apologises too much. In doing this, how does she try to engage the interest of the reader? [2]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
Only yesterday, sitting on a stifling hot bus, I found myself apologising for having the temerity to ask the only other passenger whether he would mind if I opened a window. (l.2-4) The collision was her fault, not mine. But incredibly she was the one who looked up momentarily disgruntled and affronted – and I was the one apologising. (l.6-8)	The author tries to engage the interest of the reader through different techniques: a. The use of personal anecdotes to pique the reader's interest. [1] b. The use of a question in the beginning for the reader to provide an answer. [1] c. The use of the personal pronoun 'us' to show that she was including the reader along with herself to create a sense of inclusiveness. [1] Any 2 points for 2 marks

(Question Type: Technique, Evidence)

Examiners' comments: *Most candidates saw that the author used personal anecdotes 'to pique interest', as some neatly expressed it. Some weaker responses then retold these stories becoming repetitive and overlong. Few responses noticed that just as important as what the author said as the way she said it, i.e. the techniques she adopted to draw the reader in. The most identified techniques were the author beginning with a question for the reader to provide an answer, and using the personal pronoun 'us' to show that she was including the readers along with herself to create a sense of inclusiveness.*

2. In paragraph 2, what contrasts does the author make between the attitudes of men and women towards apologising? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
One recent survey reported that 44 per cent of women believe that women apologise too much; just five per cent of women think the same of men. (l.11-13) Another study, conducted by the University of Pittsburgh, revealed that women did indeed apologise more than men. (l.14-15)	Almost half of the sample of women surveyed considered their gender tend to apologise excessively <u>while</u> males were considered not to apologise that frequently. [1]
It concluded that men have what might be termed as a 'higher threshold' for what merits an apology. Women, on the other hand, were more sensitively alert to precisely what might require an apology and their 'threshold' was lower. (l.15-18)	Men are more selective and said to apologise only when the offence is of a greater magnitude <u>but</u> women are said to be more readily aware/ inclined to consider a broader range of situations where apologies are needed. [1]
Put simply, women apologise for things that men do not apologise for. (l.18)	Women tend to apologise for matters that men deem unnecessary to express remorse for. [1]

(Question Type: Comparison)

Examiners' comments: Stronger responses recognised that the focus of the question was on the differing attitudes to apologising revealed by the survey, i.e. what men and women think or believe about how the sexes differ in their approaches to apologising. Stronger responses clearly described these differences, either by treating each sex in turn, or by succinctly describing their contrasting traits in the same sentence. Weaker responses often misread the writer's description of the attitudes revealed by the survey as facts. A further shortcoming was to take the survey's theory that men have 'a higher threshold for what merits an apology', as meaning that men simply have higher standards than women, rather than suggesting it needs an offence to be of a greater magnitude to get a man to apologise than it does for a woman to do so.

3. How does the Gmail plug-in (paragraph 3) provide further evidence for the stereotype in line 10? [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
Looking to capture the market of the female worrier ... (l.19)	The Gmail plug-in reinforces the stereotype by positioning itself exclusively to target women who apologise too much in their emails . [1]
It attempts to reverse women's propensity to apologise excessively . What it sets out to do is scan and intercept overly apologetic language that gets in the way, or undermines, the messages women write.	It also aims to identify and remove instances of exceedingly apologetic phrasing in the emails penned by women. [1]

(Question Type: Evidence)

Examiners' comments: Many of the stronger responses to this question saw that the plug-in's purpose was to stop the tendency of some women to apologise too much in their emails. Weaker responses either assumed the plug-in was aimed at women, regardless of whether they over-apologised or not, rather than targeting 'the female worrier' that the text specifies, or they saw its purpose as merely to identify or locate examples of over-apologetic phrasing rather than to remove them.

4. What does Sylvia Hewlett mean by saying that frequently apologising 'undermines your gravitas' (line 23)? [2]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
'undermines your gravitas ' (l.23)	She means that frequently apologising corrodes/significantly damages one's credibility/how one is seen by others . [1]

(Question Type: Explanation/Paraphrase)

Examiners' comments: There were many strong responses to this question which offered convincing synonyms for the two key words and dealt with both terms succinctly. They saw that 'undermines' implies significant damage and that 'gravitas' is to do with how one is seen by others, selecting words such as 'corrodes' and 'credibility'. Weaker responses chose words that did not convey the harmfulness of 'undermines' or saw 'gravitas' as how one sees oneself, rather than how one is perceived by others.

5. In lines 31-39, what is surprising about Michael Wenzel's research on people who apologise? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [3]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
His research discovered, perhaps unexpectedly , that when people apologise, they experience a sense that they are adhering to their principles of doing the right thing , reinforcing that they are people with a moral code . (l.31-34)	Wenzel's research surprisingly showed that people apologise, they get a feeling that they are abiding by their values of performing good deeds/ demonstrating their righteousness/ rectitude , instead of seeing themselves as ethical transgressors. [1]
Apologies also bring with them a feeling of increased power and authority as they (the apologisers) are the ones 'taking action to repair the wrong they have committed'. (l.34-35)	People who apologise acquire a sense of heightened influence and control as they take concrete steps to rectify/remedy their transgressions which defies conventional thinking that those who apologise might feel diminished. [1]
This research suggests that the act of apologising leads to a reduction in shame . Instead of dwelling too much on their own transgression, the apologisers are able to eat and sleep more healthily . These palpable benefits are surely the opposite of lowering self-esteem? (l.36-39)	Apologisers can dispel their feelings of disgrace/ignominy/humiliation and get on better with their lives instead of experiencing reduced self-worth/self-regard . [1]

(Question Type: Literal Paraphrasing)

Examiners' comments: *Many responses included lengthy explanations on what the expected results of apologising might be before addressing the task to identify the unexpected aspects of Wenzel's research. Most responses then did successfully identify these but weaker responses either did not identify enough of them or relied on the phrasing of the original text rather than using their own words.*

6. The author tells us in paragraph 5 what constitutes an ideal apology. What two features make an apology that is merely adequate? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
According to Lewicki's research, if you cannot, or will not, integrate all six elements and if you want to focus on the crucial ingredients of a successful apology, you should at least acknowledge blame and make an offer of repair . (l.44-46)	The two features that make an apology merely adequate are taking ownership of one's wrongdoings/ recognising one's culpability [1] and making amends for it/ making some form of restitution . [1]

(Question Type: Literal Paraphrasing)

Examiners' comments: *There were many strong responses to this question; they clearly identified the two constituents of the merely adequate apology, succinctly summarising them as taking ownership of your wrongdoings and making amends for it. Weaker responses did not offer convincing alternatives to one or both of the key terms 'acknowledge' or 'repair'.*

7. How does the author support her assertion that the apologies of famous people have ‘all sincerity stripped away’ (line 70)? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [1]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
But for famous people who have lawyers and publicist , the public apology become an important business strategy , with all sincerity stripped away. (l.68-70)	The author supports her assertion by presenting the apologies of Woods and Armstrong as insincere, being carefully scripted by lawyers and publicists and designed as damage limitation exercises shaping the narratives so that they would be in control and could protect their reputations. [1]

(Question Type: Evidence/ Paraphrasing)

Examiners’ comments: *In strong responses, it was clear that candidates had read the whole paragraph carefully and realised that the author was presenting the apologies of Woods and Armstrong as insincere, being carefully scripted by ‘lawyers and publicists’ and designed as damage limitation exercises shaping the narratives so that they would be in control and could protect their reputations. Many weaker responses were over-lengthy and omitted any reference to a calculated motive behind the words spoken by Woods and Armstrong. Instead, they gave detailed recounts of the actions of Woods and Armstrong that had created the need got an apology, or wrote that their apologies failed Lewick’s six elements of a successful apology, sometimes with these written out in*

8. In paragraph 9, how does the author suggest that apologies can encourage reappraisal of the past? **Use your own words as far as possible.** [2]

From the Text	Suggested Inference
With many in Europe still clinging to populist notions if their nation’s idyllic past and the present danger of outsiders – often from previously colonised territories – apologies could act as a way to challenge such misconceptions. (l. 79-81)	The author suggests that apologies can be a means to dispute/counter/debunk flawed ideologies/outdated and entrenched mindsets. [1]
Equally, state apologies, at their best, do not happen in vacuums – they can be reinforced with further measures aimed at reconciliation , such as more reflective school curricula and textbooks, museums and public monuments. (l. 81-84)	Apologies made by nations can be strengthened with additional methods focusing to heal old wounds. [1]
In short, perhaps apologies can be welcome starting positions for more introspection about both the past and the present. (l. 84-85)	Overall, apologies can provide a means to begin deeper contemplations that leads to greater understanding of history and current events. [1]

(Question Type: Inferential/ Paraphrasing)

Examiners’ comments: *Stronger responses included many effective ways to explain ‘to challenge misconceptions’, such as ‘to counter flawed ideologies’ and ‘to debunk outdated and entrenched mindsets’. The ideas of ‘reconciliation’ was explained less successfully, though ‘to heal old wounds’ was a particularly convincing paraphrase. Few responses found a way to express the author’s idea of ‘introspection’ (the deeper thought and reflection that leads to greater understanding of the past to create a better future). Weaker responses listed the places where this thoughtfulness might be witnessed – museums and textbooks – without describing the positive purpose such things could serve. Other weaker responses relied on the wording of the question, ‘reappraisal of the past’, and offered no explanation of the phrase. Several candidates did not give a response to this question.*

9. Using materials from paragraphs 6, 7 and 10 only, (lines 48-66 and 86-90), summarise what the author has to say the ingredients of unsuccessful and successful apologies.

Write your summary in **no more than 120 words**, not counting the opening words which are printed below. **Use your own words as far as possible.**

An unsuccessful apology is one which ...

From the Text	Suggested Paraphrase
a. Often, apologies fail to rise to the occasion ; (l.48)	is deemed ineffective/does not fulfil its intended function
b. the simple inclusion of the word 'sorry' is not in itself a guarantee of success . (l.48-49)	and merely saying 'sorry' is not sincere/genuine enough.
c. Sometimes apologisers skate over the surface ... (l.49)	It is general/superficial/vague
d. and artfully avoid ... (l.49-50)	and craftily/shrewdly shun/evade
e. ... any of the salient details . (l.50)	the significant/prominent specifics/particulars .
f. In closer relationships, the expression of such generalities simply will not do where material transgressions ... (l.51-52)	In intimate affairs, oversimplifications downplay the severity of hurtful mistakes
g. ... such as infidelity are concerned. (l.52)	like unfaithfulness .
h. Moreover, considerable attention needs to be paid to the timing of the apology. (l.52-53)	It is crucial to focus on when to apologise
i. Say sorry too quickly and you miss the important stage of reconciliation , (l.53-54)	as a swift apology may overlook the vital aspect of resolution .
j. In an age which demand instant reaction to texts, emails and 24-hour news, (l.54-55)	The emphasis on the speed of communication
k. it becomes harder and harder ... (l.55)	makes it very difficult
l. ... to wait to respond . (l.55)	to delay an answer/ a reply .
m. Waiting might be construed as apathy ... (l.55-56)	A delayed apology might be seen/mistaken as indifference
n. or not caring . (l.56)	or being unconcerned .
Ingredients for a successful apology	
o. But strategic stalling might lead to... (l.56-56)	A successful apology can involve tactical delaying
p. ... a more effective outcome ; (l.56-57)	to be efficacious
q. it is better to apologise after your partner has had the opportunity to process your transgression . (l.57-58)	as the recipient can think through/ ponder over the wrongdoing/mistake .
r. So do not rush your apology. (l.59)	So do not give a hasty apology .
s. ...it is important to focus primarily on the other person ... (l.60-61)	It is vital to concentrate mainly on the recipient
t. ...and not yourself (l.61)	than on one's self interest .
u. Forget about using a contrite apology ... 'I'm sorry if I have caused offence'. (l.61-62)	Do not rely on repentant/penitent tones

v. And avoid overdoing it. (l.63-64)	and refrain from being too long-winded/ effusive.
w. ...look at the aggrieved person directly in the eyes, (l.87)	Maintain eye contact,
x. refer explicitly to your transgression, (l.87-88)	address the wrongdoing/ mistake directly/ frankly,
y. and say what you are going to do to make amends. (l.88)	explain the measures/ steps to make up for/ compensate it,
z. And look as if you mean it. (l.88-89)	and be sincere about it/ have an earnest/ sincere facial expression.

26 possible points

(1-2pts = 1m, 3-4pts = 2m, 5-6pts = 3m, 7-8pts = 4m, 9-10pts = 5m, 11-12pts = 6m, 13-14pts = 7m, 15pts and more = 8m)

Examiners' Comments: Many candidates demonstrated strong summarising skills. Most responses conveyed their points in the required number of words, though there were a few that went well beyond the limit of 120 words. Most responses gave convincing synonyms for the key terms, except 'reconciliation', 'stalling' and 'make amends'. Strong summaries featured the varied and apt use of connectives and discourse markers to ensure fluency and coherence. There were some confusion and lack of precision in stating the various points that the author makes about the timing of an apology, while some struggled to paraphrase 'material transgressions such as infidelity' effectively. Very few made the point that the speed of communication in today's world makes strategic delaying almost impossible (though many made the same point in **Question 10** as a reason to disagree with the author's advocacy of waiting before apologising).

10. The author presents her ideas about what constitutes successful and less successful apologies.
How far do you agree with her observations, relating your arguments to your own experience and that of your society? [10]

REQUIREMENTS. Candidates should:

- Refer to the key ideas/ opinions from the writer that are related to what constitutes successful and less successful apologies.
- Evaluate how they themselves and people in their own society consider are successful and not so successful apologies and take a stand by evaluating the opinions of the author."
- Support their stand with reasoned arguments and provide examples based on their personal opinion and experience and their observations of successful and less successful apologies demonstrated in their society.

Key Ideas from the text:

What constitutes successful apologies:

1. Roy Lewick at Ohio State University concluded that there are six elements present in an effective apology: you need to express regret, explain what went wrong, acknowledge responsibility, and then declare repentance, give an offer to repair the damage and request for forgiveness.
2. In an age which demands instant reaction to texts, emails and 24-hour news, it becomes harder and harder to wait to respond. Waiting might be construed as apathy or not caring.
3. Strategic stalling might lead to a more effective outcome; it is better to apologise after your partner has had an opportunity to process your transgression.
4. It is important to focus primarily on the other person and not on yourself. Forget about using a contrite apology, and avoid overdoing it.

5. State apologies can be reinforced with further measures aimed at reconciliation, such as more reflective school curricula and textbooks, museums and public monuments. Perhaps apologies can be welcome starting positions for more introspection about both the past and the present.
6. The best strategy for delivering an apology: look the aggrieved person directly in the eyes, refer explicitly to your transgression, say what you are going to do to make amends, and look as if you mean it.

What constitutes less successful apologies:

1. Often apologies fail to rise to the occasion; the simple inclusion of the word 'sorry' is not in itself a guarantee of success.
2. Sometimes, apologisers skate over the surface and artfully avoid any of the salient features.
3. In close relationships, the expression of such generalities simply will not do where material transgression such as infidelity are concerned.
4. Moreover, considerable attention needs to be paid to the timing of the apology. Say sorry too quickly and you miss the important stage of reconciliation.

Examples

1. In the public domain, Anton Casey, a British senior wealth manager and a Singaporean permanent resident was at the centre of a social media storm after labelling Singaporeans who took public transport as 'poor people'. He even stated that he had to 'wash the stench of public transport off' himself before he could get behind the wheel of his Porsche sports car when he got it back from the workshop. Eventually, he issued an apology via a public relations firm Fulford PR but public reception was lukewarm. Netizens doxed him and subsequently, his company Crossinvest Asia relieved him of his duties and soon after he and his family migrated to Australia.
2. Amy Cheong, an assistant director at NTUC, was told to leave her job after making racist remarks about Malay weddings on social media. She made an online apology about her actions and subsequently left for Australia.
3. In the political scene, there are numerous instances of politicians apologising for their personal misdemeanours. Michael Palmer and David Ong, from the PAP and Yau Shin Leong from the Worker's Party relinquished their political positions after admitting to having improper relationships and affairs.
There are also examples of politicians apologising for inconveniences caused such as when PM Lee and Minister Gan Kim Yong apologised for the SingHealth data breach in 2018 and when Transport Minister Ong Ye Kung apologised for the MRT train breakdowns in 2020. For both cases, there were pledges to ensure smoother running of the systems and tighter security measures.
The power of apology in politics and its impact on the respective parties may be grounded on various factors and political success cannot be attributed to just the apology or its effectiveness per se.
4. In business where cut-throat competition is the norm, there are cases where companies transgressed the moral latitudes permitted. For example, Singtel apologised to rival telcos M1 and StarHub for a smear campaign promoted by an agency it engaged. M1 and StarHub subsequently accepted the apology with no further action taken.
5. For customers at restaurants, it is not uncommon for orders to be mixed up or the food served to be less than satisfactory. When such instances occur, well-trained managers will engage in service recovery with the intent to convert a customer from being unhappy to being content, so that they are likely to do business with the customer again. Some techniques could involve offering to replace the order, an additional serving of dessert or discount vouchers for future visits.

Examiners' Comments

Some responses were brief. **The stronger responses were well structured and included a brief introduction, clear links between paragraphs and a conclusion. They were focused and made measured and nuanced observations, agreeing and disagreeing with at least one of the author's arguments.** Those who wrote at greater length tended to rely on lengthy descriptions of their chosen examples, rather than analysing and evaluating these while considering the author's views regarding apologising. Weaker responses often quoted at length from the original text and then wrote 'What the author means is...', followed by a needless paraphrase, rather than focusing on one of the author's opinions and subjecting it to close examination. Weaker responses also lacked pertinent examples to justify sweeping generalisations or merely described an action which caused offence rather than suggesting reasons for the offence and its reception, or assessing the effectiveness of the apology offered for it.

Generally, candidates chose contemporary examples to support their exploration of the necessity or otherwise of apologising, and what constitutes an effective apology, and focused on the misdemeanours and subsequent apologies of recently disgraced influencers like Dee Kosh, figures from popular culture, often suggesting that for such people it is imperative to apologise immediately to maintain their public status. Other discussions included: the issue arising in the run-up to the 2020 elections, the problems of the MRT transport system, and the experiences of Monica Bey. Responses with a wider historical perspectives referred to former times, such as Japan's wartime occupation of the Malay Peninsula, or to the early days of Singaporean independence.

Some of the **stronger responses included effective references to personal experience such as getting into trouble with parents and highlighted the growing tension between the older and younger generations in the wider Singaporean context**. Other stronger responses **related similar experiences and described the differing cultural and family values in China, exploring, comparing, and contrasting Confucian ideas with more contemporary Western liberal values**; such contrasts created an **arresting juxtaposition of the views held by younger and older generations regarding the necessity or otherwise of apologising**. The notion of 'losing face' often featured in strong responses, as did **the traditional reluctance to apologise to someone more junior in social status or age**.

Many of the stronger responses **explored the place of apologising in Singaporean culture**. Some candidates felt that Singaporeans are afraid of offending, so they apologise a great deal, with 'the frequency of the apology correlating with its effectiveness'. On the other hand, many felt Singapore is a society where apologising is seen as a weakness, a loss of face, 'only to be done pragmatically to save one's job or promotional prospects'. If one felt the need to apologise, it was best done immediately 'to shorten the emotional trauma and distress of the aggrieved', and preferably not face-to-face but via one's phone, 'where a simple tap on the screen suffices', with no physical confrontation or embarrassment involved. In general, **stronger responses showed a personal and informed engagement with the topic rather than a detached and superficial one**.

The **stronger responses were also characterised by a diversity and sophistication of vocabulary, phrasing and sentence structure, allied to an effective use of idiom**, for example: 'he wouldn't have gone public had he been caught red-handed'. Occasionally, the ambition exceeded the control, or the chosen lexical item was not quite appropriate in the context ('making amendments' is not the same as 'making amends'); for the most part, candidates demonstrated a very assured command of English, using a range of discourse markers to enhance fluency and cogency.

When there were grammatical errors, these often related to agreement between singular and plural subjects and verbs, especially in longer sentences where the subject and verb were not adjacent. There was also some insecurity shown in the use of the pronoun 'one', for example "one has to mind their manners" or 'one must acknowledge their mistake'. Weaker responses also featured inaccurate prepositions ('one agrees with' someone, not 'to' someone) or superfluous prepositions ('one emphasises', not 'one emphasises on') and omitted to use capital letters for proper nouns such as Asia and Singapore.